

Self-kindness instructions – Home practice

The instructions below take the ideas we discussed in our in-person session and provide guidance for practicing them at home. The aim of both the session and these practice instructions is to strengthen what we refer to as **self-kindness**, and to help it replace self-criticism. As people go through this practice, some notice their thoughts and feelings verbally to themselves, and others like to write them down (for example, using a Self-kindness Monitoring Sheet). You may want to try both ways and see which work best for you. You can write things down, speak silently to yourself, and do this work in silence.

1. As we had seen in our session, the first step towards self-kindness involves noticing your own self-criticism. This isn't always easy – self-criticism sometimes sounds like “the truth” and feels incontrovertible, but we invite you to try and see whether you can put into words any critical, demanding, or demeaning message that may be there in a moment in which you feel bad about something. What does the criticism sound like? What tone of voice does the Critic have? What words or phrases does the Critic use? Is this voice similar in any way to someone you know who was or is critical of you?
2. Try and see this voice as we had done in our session – imagining it as a figure sitting across from you, and speaking to you. For example, if you've just discovered that you're late in submitting some assignment, notice whether this Critic says something like “you're such a screwup”, “you never do anything right”, or something similar? What does it feel like to hear this voice? Do you notice any physical reaction in your body when you hear it? Any weakness, maybe a knot in your stomach, or heaviness in your chest? Are there any emotions you're noticing? Any thoughts?
3. Now that you've placed the Critic outside of you, see if you can speak back to it and get it to soften its message. Say something like “I know why you show up, and I get that you have my best interests at heart, but these words and this tone aren't helping”. The point is not to get into a battle with the Critic, to prove it wrong, or to erase it completely – instead, the point is to *work with it on softening up* so that its effect on you will not be as upsetting emotionally and physically.
4. When you're ready, switch to an alternative view of the dialogue – from the perspective of a Kind Voice, a Compassionate Self. From this perspective, think of the situation in a friendly and caring way, as you would towards a friend. Speak to both your Criticized and Critic selves, trying to emphasize the universality of the situation: “we all have better days and worse days”; “even if you did screw up in this specific moment, that doesn't make you a screw-up”; “what is it you need to make things better now?”; “would it help if you took a break, went out for a walk, and then sat down to do the work?”. Check in with the Criticized self and see what help it needs to get back on track with the right kind of motivation.
5. As you are voicing the Kind Voice, try using some physical self-soothing technique – a couple of deep breaths, slow soothing strokes of your fore-arm, etc.. These self-soothing acts tend to activate the self-calming (parasympathetic) neurological system even if our thoughts and feelings aren't there yet. By acting kindly both verbally and non-verbally, you will be strengthening this important skill of self-kindness.

Whether you used the Self-kindness Monitoring Sheet as you went through these steps or not, we recommend taking a moment at the end of each day to write down at least one instance of self-kindness you had engaged in that day. At first, these may be very small acts, but making room for them in your daily life is likely, over time, to tip the balance between harshness and kindness in how you relate to yourself.